# Iron Gates trip – following Jondalar to the Sharamudoi

Inspired by Jean Auel's *The Valley of Horses*. According to Don's Maps, Auel based the Sharamudoi on a mix of several sites in the Iron Gates (Đerdap / Porțile de Fier) gorge, where the Danube cuts through the Carpathians on the Serbian–Romanian border.

- **Who:** two couples, staying in guesthouses
- **Length:** 10–11 days
- **Getting around:** round trip by air to Belgrade (BEG), rental car, cycling for one day
- **When:** May–June or September (see "Season" below)

## Itinerary

| Day | Route | Highlights | Night |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Fly to BEG → Novi Sad (≈1 h) | Petrovaradin fortress at sunset | Novi Sad |
| 2 | Fruška Gora + Titel | Fruška Gora NP hike; Titel hill above the Tisza–Danube confluence ("the Sister") | Novi Sad |
| 3 | Novi Sad → Belgrade → Golubac (≈3.5 h) | Kalemegdan (Sava–Danube confluence); Golubac fortress | Golubac |
| 4 | Golubac → Kučevo → Majdanpek → Donji Milanovac | Ceremošnja cave (verify opening), Rajkova cave | Donji Milanovac |
| 5 | **Sharamudoi day** | Lepenski Vir site + museum; Veliki Štrbac or Ploče viewpoint hike | Donji Milanovac |
| 6 | Cycle the Kazan | Donji Milanovac → Kazan → Hajdučka vodenica → Tekija (≈45 km), taxi back | Donji Milanovac |
| 7 | Cross at Iron Gates I dam (Kladovo ↔ Drobeta) → Dubova | Romanian bank road (DN57), Mraconia monastery, Decebalus sculpture | Dubova / Eșelnița |
| 8 | **Cave day (split group)** | Ponicova + Veterani (see below) | Dubova / Eșelnița |
| 9 | Drobeta → dam → Kladovo → Zlot | Iron Gates Region Museum, Trajan's bridge, Fetislam fortress; Lazareva cave | Zlot / Bor |
| 10 | Zlot → Belgrade | Morning hike in Lazar's Canyon; evening in Belgrade | Belgrade |
| 11 | Fly home | | |

Optional extensions:

- **Romanian nature (+2 days):** Nera Gorge and the Beușnița and Bigăr waterfalls (1.5–2 h inland from Dubova)

- **Bulgaria (+1–2 days):** Belogradchik rocks and Magura cave (prehistoric paintings), reached from Kladovo / Negotin

## Day 8 – split group

**Cave group:** a guided Ponicova traverse (2–3 h, mud, helmet). Bring a headlamp and clothes you don't mind getting dirty. Boat access depends on the water level, and high water can close the cave.

**Non-cave group:** pick one or two of these, all within a few kilometres of Dubova:

- **Ciucarul Mare hike:** a short, steep climb (count on 2–3 h round trip) to the best viewpoint over the Cazanele Mari, chamois cliffs in Shamudoi style. It takes about as long as the cave visit.
- **Boat trip** to the Decebalus sculpture, Mraconia monastery and Tabula Traiana (the Roman inscription on the Serbian bank, best seen from the water). Boat trips also stop at **Veterani**, which is short, easy and dry compared with Ponicova.
- **Ciucarul Mic** or the Dubova bay shore: gentler walks with views back into the gorge.
- Swimming or a slow lunch on a terrace by the Danube in Dubova.

Meeting up afterwards: if the cave group exits on the river side, the boat operator can bring them back to Dubova; agree the time and place in advance.

## Auel-related places

- **Lepenski Vir:** trapezoidal houses on a river terrace (the model for the Sharamudoi houses), fish-faced sculptures; 9500–6000 BC, so later than Jondalar's time
- **Iron Gates Mesolithic:** Vlasac, Padina, Hajdučka vodenica, Schela Cladovei; mostly flooded or with little visible on site, but covered by museums in Kladovo and Drobeta
- **Cuina Turcului (Dubova):** the region's only rock shelter; probably largely under the reservoir – check
- **Peștera cu Oase:** about 40,000-year-old modern human remains; closed to visitors
- **The Sister = Tisza:** joins the Danube near Titel (day 2)

## Season

- **May–June:** green and lush, long days. Spring high water may close Ponicova or block boat entry.
- **September:** warm water, lower river (better cave access), grape harvest, fewer people. Veterani is open May–October.
- July–August: up to 35 °C; caves and the river help, but hiking is hot.

## Practicalities

- **Rental car – important:** at least Enterprise in Belgrade *excludes Romania* (along with Bulgaria, Kosovo and Albania). Ask several companies, including local Belgrade agencies, for written permission for Romania ≥ 7 working days before pickup (expect ≈ €60 for the green card / cross-border fee). Fallback: leave the car in Kladovo and get a taxi or guesthouse transfer across the dam to Dubova (≈ 50 km). Boats from Dubova cover the Romanian sights, so you hardly need a car there. (Check whether taxis can cross the border.)
- **Mobile:** Serbia is not in the EU, so there's no EU roaming; buy a local SIM or eSIM.
- **Currency:** Serbian dinar (RSD) and Romanian leu (RON); carry some cash for boats and guides.
- **Bikes (day 6):** few rental options in Golubac / Donji Milanovac; book ahead. The gorge road has unlit tunnels, so bring lights.
- **Guesthouses:** roughly €30–60 per room per night.

## Operators and opening times

Found online; prices are snapshots and may be out of date.

| What | Who / where | Details |
|---|---|---|
| Boat trips in the Cazane (Ponicova, Veterani, Decebalus, Tabula Traiana) | **Cazanele Dunării**, Dubova – cazaneledunarii.com, +40 744 612 005 | Daily 09–18. Shared 1 h: 50 lei pp (min. 6). **Private boat ≤ 4 pax: 350 lei (≈ €70)**, ≤ 8 pax: 500 lei, incl. guide. Veterani +10 lei pp, Tabula Traiana +15 lei pp. Boat entry into Ponicova depends on the water level. |
| Ponicova on foot | Iron Gates Natural Park (pnportiledefier.ro) | Free, not developed for tourists. Get a guide for the full 2–3 h traverse (ask the park or the boat operator). |
| Ceremošnja cave | Near Kučevo, +381 63 238090 | Apr–Oct, daily 09–18 (2024 info). 40 min guided tour. |
| Rajkova cave | 2–2.5 km from Majdanpek | Show cave since 1975, 10–12 °C. Opening hours not found – check. |
| Lazareva cave | Zlot, +381 30 459 020 (TO Bor +381 30 24166) | May–Oct, daily 09–16. ≈ 300 RSD (2022). 40 min tour. |
| Lepenski Vir | Visitor centre, between Donji Milanovac and Golubac | Closed in February; summer about 09–20. Price not found (cheap). |
| Bikes (day 6) | Rooms Jankovic, Donji Milanovac (rents bikes); Miko’s bike shop (repairs) | Alternative: guided MTB tour near Golubac (explore-serbia.rs, ≈ 10,600 RSD). |

## Guesthouse shortlist

| Base | Nights | Candidates |
|---|---|---|
| Novi Sad | 2 | Lanterna Rooms City Center, Kombinat Rooms City Center, Apartments Stojic (≈ €55–90 per room) |
| Golubac | 1 | Guest House Keserovic (9.3, river view), Guest House Lona (by the promenade near the fortress, sleeps up to 6), Moms House (Dunavski kej) |
| Donji Milanovac | 3 | Apartmani Kuljanin (on the water, terrace), Vuk Apartment (centre, renovated 2024), Vila Hedona (view, steep access), Dunavski Raj 2 (in the national park) |
| Dubova | 2 | Casa de Oaspeti Dunarea la Cazane (≈ 9.3 / 500 reviews), Pensiunea Cazanele Dunarii (9.4), Telteu Florian (≈ 8.8) |
| Zlot / Bor | 1 | Not researched – look in Brestovačka Banja (14 km) or Bor (20 km) |
| Belgrade | 1 | Near the airport or in the centre |

## Rough budget (4 people, 11 days / 10 nights)

| Item | Assumption | Total (4 pax) |
|---|---|---|
| Flights CPH ⇄ BEG | Air Serbia direct, ≈ €150–300 pp return | €600–1,200 |
| Accommodation | 2 rooms × 10 nights × €40–70 | €800–1,400 |
| Rental car | 10 days, compact estate, + cross-border fee ≈ €60 | €400–700 |
| Fuel + tolls | ≈ 1,300 km | €150–200 |
| Food & drink | €25–40 pp/day (Serbia and Romania are cheap) | €1,100–1,800 |
| Activities | Caves, Lepenski Vir, fortresses, private boat, Ponicova guide, bikes | €350–600 |
| Misc. | eSIMs, parking, taxi on bike day, Dubova transfer | €150–250 |
| **Total** | | **≈ €3,500–6,000 (≈ €900–1,500 pp)** |

Travel insurance is not included.

## To check / book

- [ ] Flights to BEG
- [ ] Rental car with *written* permission for Romania (or the Kladovo fallback)
- [ ] Private boat + Ponicova guide (Cazanele Dunării)
- [ ] Rajkova cave opening times; Lepenski Vir price
- [ ] Bike rental for day 6 (Rooms Jankovic?)
- [ ] Accommodation in Zlot / Bor
- [ ] Status of Cuina Turcului

## Sources


- Don’s Maps – Sharamudoi
- Don’s Maps – Archeology for Jean Auel fans
- Wikipedia – Lepenski Vir
- Wikipedia – Iron Gates Mesolithic
- Pro-Mehedinți – Ponicova Cave
- Pro-Mehedinți – Veterani Cave
- Kayak trip Dubova → Orșova (blog)
- Cazanele Dunării – boat trips
- Showcaves – Ponicova
- Showcaves – Ceremošnja
- Showcaves – Rajkova
- Showcaves – Zlotske pećine
- Pro-Mehedinți – Lepenski Vir Museum
- Enterprise Belgrade airport – cross-border terms
- Explore Serbia – MTB tour Golubac
- Rooms Jankovic, Donji Milanovac
- Kayak – Guest House Keserovic, Golubac
- Kayak – Pension Decebal, Dubova
- Kayak – CPH–BEG